FORCED LABOR OF CHILDREN IN UZBEKISTAN'S COTTON INDUSTRY

Author(s): Bilal A. Bhat

Source: *International Journal on World Peace*, DECEMBER 2013, Vol. 30, No. 4 (DECEMBER 2013), pp. 61-85

Published by: Paragon House

Stable URL: https://www.jstor.org/stable/24543696

JSTOR is a not-for-profit service that helps scholars, researchers, and students discover, use, and build upon a wide range of content in a trusted digital archive. We use information technology and tools to increase productivity and facilitate new forms of scholarship. For more information about JSTOR, please contact support@jstor.org.

Your use of the JSTOR archive indicates your acceptance of the Terms & Conditions of Use, available at https://about.jstor.org/terms



is collaborating with JSTOR to digitize, preserve and extend access to *International Journal on World Peace*

This content downloaded from 185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

FORCED LABOR OF CHILDREN IN UZBEKISTAN'S COTTON INDUSTRY

Bilal A. Bhat

Assistant Professor of Sociology
J & K Inst. of Management, Public Admin. & Rural Dev.
Srinagar
Jammu and Kashmir
190001 INDIA

Bilal A. Bhat is an Assistant Professor of Sociology in the Faculty of Social Science at Jammu & Kashmir Institute of Management, Public Administration & Rural Development. He earned his Ph.D. in Sociology at the University of Kashmir. He extensively traveled throughout Central Asia, especially Tashkent, Namangan, Andijan, Fergana, Bukhara, Samarkand and Khiva in Uzbekistan. In addition his book, *Rehabilitation of Child Labor: Problems and Prospects,* he has published numerous articles on Central Asia especially Uzbekistan.

Lack of skilled manpower, sophisticated technology, and marketization are a new basis for child labor in Central Asia, particularly in Uzbekistan. Agriculture, which comprises 40 percent of GDP of Uzbekistan, has turned backwards from the Soviet period when refined technology was provided by the Russians.

Uzbekistan, the second largest producer of cotton in the world, now mostly cultivates cotton with forced labor by school children. Schools are closed down for two to three months and all the children and teachers are ordered by the autocratic state to take part in cotton-picking. Daily quotas are assigned to everyone.

This article is based on extensive field investigation in Uzbekistan. School children, their employers, and their parents were interviewed. Also, in-depth interviews of human rights activists, senior citizens, academicians, government officials, and social workers were conducted to make the findings of the study holistic.

INTRODUCTION

Child labor is ubiquitous in almost all Central Asian States, but in diverse ways and to different degrees. Tajikistan uses child labor as a "lifeline for their families" who are strained by extreme poverty to take their children out of school and plant them to work on the family farm or marketplace. According to unofficial estimates, 45-55 percent of children from the 10-14 age groups especially from low income families are engaged in physical labor and this percentage is increasing in Dushanbe and other large cities in Tajikistan.

The Kazakh legislation includes provisions on the employment of minors, such as the age limit, safety measures and various safeguards, although many children work illicitly, predominantly in the rural areas. The types of labor performed by children include subsistence farming, work in

This content downloaded from
185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

private enterprises, family business, and others. The socio-demographical and economic situation in Kazakhstan is conducive to the use of cheap child labor, both during the agricultural season, irrespective of the educational process, and by family and criminal businesses. Since the collapse of the Soviet Union, the use of child labor in Kyrgyzstan has become widespread, especially in the southern regions, where tobacco, rice and cotton are cultivated. Children are involved in transporting (unloading) and selling goods and luggage on the streets and in the markets, in addition to collecting bottles and aluminium. An overview of the Turkmen legislation on labor rights of minors shows that the state is party to international legal documents regulating this issue. Pupils, including those from junior grades, have to work, throughout the cotton picking season in Turkmenistan. The use of child labor in Uzbekistan has largely stemmed from the difficulties of the post-Soviet transition period, which have stimulated the use of children's labor (Bilal Bhat, 2011, p. 86).

The use of child labor in Uzbekistan has largely stemmed from the difficulties of the post-Soviet transition period, which have stimulated the use of children's labor.

CENTRAL ASIAN RESOURCES AND COTTON MONOCULTURE

The indigenous, primitive feudal economy of Central Asia was different from that of Russia both structurally and qualitatively. The rulers in Russia understood very well that in order to successfully exploit this region it had to be structurally integrated within the broad framework of the Russian capitalist order. This gave rise to the need for well-developed transportation and communication that served their two objectives: one to meet the interest of their industry, and the other to fulfill their military and political aims. So building up a strong infrastructure became their first priority, and we still see a world class infrastructure all over the republic today. Especially in the urban and semi-urban areas like Tashkent, Samarkand, and Bukhara there are excellent roads and the Tashkent Metro system makes the whole city look like a well-integrated unit.

Before the close of the nineteenth century, Russian private capital started displaying more interest in the exploitation of the resources of the

This content downloaded from
185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

region, as by then military security had been established. Until the middle of the 1890s, the Russian capitalist class displayed subdued interest in the development and exploitation of indigenous resources. Experts believe that from then to the outbreak of the 1917 revolution, the Russian capitalist class became involved in most of the economic ventures in the region. Most of the industries built during Soviet times have either been closed or became defunct immediately after the independence. Much of the skilled manpower, mostly from Russia, left Uzbekistan and industrial equipment designed for the industry no longer was sent by Russia. Consequently, Uzbekistan was left with hundreds of thousands of unskilled and semi-skilled laborers jobless.

The extension of the Trans-Caspian railroad to Tashkent in 1898 put an end to the isolation of the local capital that "opened Central Asia to Russian Capital." Historically, the growing of cotton in Central Asia's traditional economy did not structurally differ from any other local industry. Even long before the region was annexed to the Russian empire, two thirds of the total volume of goods imported from Central Asia to Russia was in the form of raw cotton, yarn, and related items. The introduction of the American variety of cotton became so popular that it soon supplanted the old variety and increased the volume of trade with Russia. By the year 1890, almost the entire cotton area of Turkistan was sown with the American type of cotton, and between 1886 and 1900, the cultivation increased from 41,000 desyatins to 92,888 desyatins.*

In the areas like Samarkand, Syr-Darya, and the Trans-Caspian provinces, cotton cultivation comprised as much as 75 percent to 80 percent of the cultivated acreage. The Central Asian industry had received a boost as a result of the world-wide cotton crisis arising out of the American civil war. By 1911-12, 52 percent of the needs of the Russia's cotton textile industry were being met by the cotton brought from Turkistan and by 1914-15 it had gone up to 70 percent. There is no doubt that the Russian textile industry was heavily dependent on the production of cotton in Central Asia. All this not only led to the emergence of a number of banks and credit institutions, but it also resulted in widespread indebtedness of the small farmers and many of them lost their holdings to the money lenders

*One desyatin is about 3 acres.

This content downloaded from
185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

and traders and were reduced to the status of mere sharecroppers. The more cotton shipments from Turkistan, the fatter the textile industry of Russia became. In 1888 these totalled much less than one million poods,* but by 1896 they had gone up to nearly 3.5 million poods. During 1896-1900, these climbed to about 4.9 million poods and finally by 1907 they reached to 10.7 million poods (Sharma, 1979, p.9). The acreage under cotton cultivation between 1885 and 1915 increased from 41.4 to 541.9 thousand desyatins.

The whole Central Asian region is famous for its cotton production, but its main concentration was in Uzbekistan, which contributes around 60 percent of the total production. The Soviet authorities had focused continuously and consistently on increasing the production for which they tried to bring more and more area under its cultivation on one side and improve the irrigation facilities at the other side. To improve the irrigation facilities they had to invest heavily in building huge irrigation canals largely from Amu Darya and Syr Darya.

The whole Central Asian region is famous for its cotton production, but its main concentration was in Uzbekistan, which contributes around 60 percent of the total production.

THE ROLE OF AGRICULTURE IN UZBEK ECONOMY

Uzbek agriculture is the largest sector of the economy. As measured in terms of GDP, employment, and export potential makes it indispensable for the economy as a whole, and more so for rural development. It is the leading sector and forms the basis of the entire national economy. Specifically, it plays a vital role in economy by engaging 60 percent of the rural population and is one of the main sources of hard currency earnings. The agricultural sector accounts for 12.2 percent of production assets, 34.4 percent of employment, 70 percent of trade, 30.1 percent of GDP, and 60 percent of exports. The country produces 3.5–3.7 million tons of cotton every year of which 1–1.2 million tons of cotton fiber is of world standard and Uzbekistan is considered a world leader in developing high-yield strains of cotton.

*A pood is a Russian unit equal to about 36.11 pounds.

This content downloaded from
185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

The cultivation of cotton makes Uzbekistan one of the world's biggest regions of irrigation farming. Using more than 50 percent of the river basins of the Amu Darya and Syr Darya rivers accounts for only 20 percent of the water needed for irrigation, and the remaining 80 percent comes from Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan. Uzbekistan has the advantage of a warm climate and a long growing season. In the Soviet period, these conditions offered high and reliable crop yields. Soviet centralized agricultural policy focused on Uzbekistan's favorable climate for cotton cultivation. As Uzbekistan became a net exporter of cotton and a narrow range of other agricultural products, it required large-scale imports of grain and other foods that were not grown in sufficient quantities in its fields. Hence the agrarian system of the entire Central Asia was shaped in a particular way that the present political rulers are trying to continue. This means collectivization, the hallmark of the Soviet legacy. At the same time they are in the midst of a transitional phase of their economy. While traditional agriculture was poorly developed, many structural distortions were introduced in the economy of the region that were favorable for state capitalism in successor regimes.

Agriculture remained important even when Central Asia entered into greater industrial development in the 1960s. Since then the emphasis shifted to a more complex industrial structure, focused on the qualitative development of industry, based on the scientific and technological revolution that accelerated development. Uzbekistan, for example, developed mechanical engineering, iron and steel, non-ferrous metal industries, air craft building, chemical industries, gas extraction, fuel and energy industry, and gold mining. It exported cotton, textile machinery, and other complex industrial products.

This was a remarkable achievement within a relatively short period of time, considering the fact that, not so long ago in the 1920s, Uzbekistan's main item of export was primitive hoes and ploughing equipment (Ajay Patnaik, 2003, p. 43). Agricultural and cattle-breeding processes in Turkistan and to a greater extent in Khiva and Bukhara were primitive in nature, using antiquated equipment, and the labor productivity and land yield were very low. The land, water and animals were concentrated in the hands of feudal lords and kulaks (Devendra Kaushik, 1970, p. 67).

Despite the Soviet developments in agriculture, we must underline that most of Central Asia is arid and a considerable part is covered with desert,

This content downloaded from
185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

leaving very few areas of the region suited for agriculture. There is no possibility for any agriculture without fertile soil and water, so the agricultural activity has to be confined to areas where irrigation is available for most of the year. The Fergana valley is the most fertile region of Uzbekistan. Made up of alluvial soil with access to mountain rivers, it is most suited for agriculture and allied activities. That is why it is famous for cotton cultivation, not only in Central Asia, but the entire world. However, the valley is densely populated, and it is very difficult for the majority of inhabitants to find work to sustain themselves.

POVERTY IN UZBEKISTAN

Poverty is one of the main reasons for the unprecedented emigration by the working population in the region. Uzbekistan is the most populous Central Asian country and has the largest armed forces. In addition to being one of the worlds largest producers of cotton, it is rich in natural resources, including oil, gas, and gold. However, poverty and unemployment are widespread. Two thirds of the population of Uzbekistan lives in the countryside, and most in large families. About 38.7 percent of the total population of the country is below 16 years of age, down from 43.1 percent in 1991. Many children live in regions with high rates of both population density and unemployment, such as Fergana, Kashkadarya, and Samarkand. These demographic, social, and economic factors create objective preconditions for the use of child labor in the countryside. In rural areas, 31 percent of families have 6-7 members, and 11 percent of families have nine or more members (State Statistical Agency, 2003, p. 35). During the transition to the market economy, the number of children has decreased in both urban and rural areas. The political and economic changes have had demographic implications. Approximately 27 percent of the population lives below the poverty line and cannot satisfy its basic needs. In rural areas, around 35 percent have a higher chance of becoming poor (OMCT, 2006).

OVERVIEW OF LITERATURE

The study "We Live Subject to their Orders" by International Labor Rights Forum (ILRF, 2008) based on a three-province survey of forced child labor in Uzbekistan's 2008 cotton harvest clearly shows that parents, children,

This content downloaded from
185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

teachers, and even farmers who benefit, all deplore the forced labor of children. This study shows that root causes of forced labor in Uzbekistan are not poverty, tradition, or lack of education, but the nature of the industry and the state control over rural society. UNICEF published several large survey reports on the status of women and children in Uzbekistan. Reports prepared by Uzbekistan Human Rights Forum detailed forced child labor practices in the 2007 harvest and the 2008 spring planting season. The report "Invisible to the World: the Dynamics of Forced Child Labor in the Cotton Sector of Uzbekistan" by SOAS, University of London (Kandiyoti, 2008), concludes that child labor is not simply a response to rural poverty at the household or community level but is an intrinsic feature of the current structure of the cotton sector in Uzbekistan. Save the Children (UK) commissioned research in Uzbekistan in 2002 that covered the regions of Namangan, Jizak, Karakalpakstan and the city of Tashkent. Its findings presented evidence of the exploitation of child labor and related violations of national and international laws.

There is an increasing tendency to view child labor as a form of welfare, rather than purely an economic strategy. This article is intended to correct this.

A number of surveys conducted on the child labor in the cotton industry of Uzbekistan do not present an integrated picture of the problem. There is an increasing tendency to view child labor as a form of welfare, rather than purely an economic strategy. This article is intended to correct this.

OBJECTIVES

The study broadly followed the following objectives:

1. To study child labor in the cotton sector of Uzbekistan as a consequence of a premeditated strategy of the government of Uzbekistan.
2. To explain the intensity of work and low reimbursement, and to show how the exposure to dust, chemicals, pesticides, defoliants, which are abundantly used in the cotton fields before the collection of cotton, impinge on the health of these children.
3. To stimulate egislation in Uzbekistan on children labor rights and

This content downloaded from
185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

to promote norms of international law related to the practice of child labor.

4. To provide recommendations and suggestions for the solution of the problem in greater Uzbekistan.

METHODOLOGY

This study of child labor in the cotton industry of Uzbekistan is an attempt to understand this phenomenon using a comprehensive sociological field investigation in Uzbekistan. Cotton farming impacts all Uzbekistan, especially the heart of Uzbek cotton oblasts* Kashkadarya, Samarkand, Bukhara, Khourizm, Sukhandarya, the autonomous Republic of Karakalpakistan, Namangan, Fergana, and Andijan. Logistics made it difficult to study the entire country, therefore this study focused on the oblasts of Namangan, Fergana, Kashkadarya, and Samarkand. These oblasts have large agricultural areas and most of the population belongs to the farming class. In this study, multi-stage sampling was used. In the first stage Tashkent and Fergana were selected. Both primary and secondary sources of information are used in the study. Sources on the internet and published works of the ILO, World Bank, UNICEF, UNESCO, UNDP, UNCHR, WTO, Anti-Slavery International, International Labor Rights Forum, Human Rights Watch, International Confederation of Free Trade Unions (ICFTU), Global March Against Child Labor (GMACL), Save the Children UK, Environmental Justice Foundation UK, Human Rights Defenders in Uzbekistan, and other UN agencies reports and studies are used as primary source of information. Discussions were also held with scholars with knowledge of the cotton industry and its socio-economic dimensions, with a view to understand the hidden causes of child labor, and also to know how they viewed the labor laws and child labor in Uzbekistan. Relevant data was also collected from published documents, policy notes, and reports. The secondary sources of data were collected from books, periodicals, journals, articles, and newspapers. These sources represent all major parts of the country, and our study focused on areas having a high concentration of working children. The data and information collected from the field as well as from different other sources, was both statistically and qualitatively evaluated and sociologically analyzed in the light of other studies.

* An oblast is a type of administrative division in Slavic countries.

This content downloaded from
185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

RESULTS AND DISCUSSIONS

1. Cotton in Uzbekistan: Uzbekistan is the second largest exporter of cotton in the world, selling over 800,000 tons of cotton every year. Europe is its major buyer. But while the former Soviet Republic is at the forefront of global cotton production, its human rights and environmental record lags far behind the rest of the world. Forced child labor, human rights violations, excessive pesticide use, the draining of an ocean, and severe poverty are all rife in cotton production in Uzbekistan. Side by side with the human rights violations caused by cotton, is an environmental catastrophe of astonishing proportions. In order to irrigate its 1.47 million hectares under cotton, Uzbekistan's regime has all but eradicated the Aral Sea. Once the world's fourth largest body of water, the Aral is now reduced to just 15 percent of its former volume. Appalling mismanagement of this vital water resource has resulted in the disappearance of the Aral's 24 species of native fish from its waters, the drying out of associated wetlands, and the creation of tens of thousands of environmental refugees: the former dependents of the Aral's ecosystem.

In order to irrigate its 1.47 million hectares under cotton, Uzbekistan's regime has all but eradicated the Aral Sea.

2. Cotton and School Children in Uzbekistan: The data clearly demonstrates that child participation in the cotton harvest is extremely widespread and that there has been no fundamental change from earlier years. Most children were involved over a two-month period, though echoing attempts the previous year to limit the use of child labor. Initially it was just the older children who were mobilized (aged 15–16) but very soon after younger ones (aged 12–14) joined them. In all regions of Uzbekistan, government officials mobilize children in an attempt to ensure that state cotton quotas are met. Schools are closed down and children as young as seven are sent to the fields to pick cotton by hand. Headmasters are given quotas which dictate how much each student is to harvest; those who fail to meet their targets, or who pick a low quality crop, are reportedly punished with detention and told that their grades will suffer. Children who run away from the cotton fields, or who refuse to take part, can face expulsion

This content downloaded from
185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

from school. Accurate statistics on children employed in the cotton sector in Uzbekistan are difficult to obtain, but the London-based rights group Environmental Justice Foundation (EJF) reports around 200,000 children work in the major cotton-producing region Ferghana every year. While we could not verify this figure, certainly tens of thousands are involved each year. According to UNICEF in 2000, an estimated 22.6 percent of Uzbek children aged between 5 and 14 worked at least part-time, primarily in cotton harvesting.

In Soviet times up to two thirds of Uzbekistan's cotton was harvested by machine. Today this figure has dropped to just 10 percent, with the majority of Uzbek cotton gathered by hand, often by children. According to reports from nine of Uzbekistan's twelve territorial units, (Jizzakh, Fergana, Namangan, Syr Daria, Surkhandaria, Bukhara, Khorezm, Tashkent and Samarkand provinces) by the third week of September local governments and school administrators sent children as young as the seventh grade (ages 13–14), and in some cases as young as fifth grade (11–12) out to the fields to pick cotton. By the end of September, pressure to bring in the harvest before rains led local officials to order the smallest school children, from first grade on, to join the labor on the harvest. In Fergana, schools are closed and children are sent out in September. A week earlier, those schools force children to sign statements that they will remain in school after the end of semester. Experts suggest that the statements are intended to give local government officials plausible deniability if the children's presence in the fields is challenged.

Experts suggested that statements signed by school children are intended to give local government officials plausible deniability if the children's presence in the fields was challenged.

3. Structural Exploitation: All cotton workers, including the child laborers, have become subject to government policies that stress high yields of cotton to bring major income to the national budget. All parts of cotton production, from planting to selling, are state controlled. Under this control, the government artificially forces prices to be as cheap as possible—employing approximately children all over the country to keep costs down.

This content downloaded from
185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

Local governments and educational institutions help the central government push children at secondary schools, colleges, lyceums, institutes, and universities to engage in cotton picking.

Cotton production in Uzbekistan is based on exploitation of the population. Millions of poverty stricken rural residents work in cotton fields for scant payment, or even free. Forced child labor and other types of abuses are commonplace. High profits then get divvied up between small groups of state elites with powerful political connections. Such an economic system is viable only under political repression, normally triggering the mobilization of mass labor working below market prices. The political regime in Uzbekistan is regarded as one of the most repressive in the world. Opposition activists and human rights defenders are persecuted. Lack of public mass media reports cause most abuses go unexposed.

4. Composition of Work and the Conditions: Children work for long hours in the fields during the spring season. Since the sun comes up early and it gets hot, the children come out to the fields at 6:30 or 7:00 a.m. They have an hour or two for lunch, and then they come out again for work until 7 or 7:30 p.m. Their working day lasts ten to twelve hours. In the days when the schools are closed down and lessons are cancelled, the children together with their teachers come out for the mass khashar (forced labor). At other times during the spring season, children are sent out to the fields once the school day is complete or after a shortened school day. School children are subject to mobilization even on the weekends, and can work 11–12 hours per day or more. "Farmers" reluctance to spend funds on gasoline requires that children must often make their way home on foot, which lengthens their work day even more. School children working in the cotton fields rarely return home before 9 or 10 p.m. during the spring season.

Uzbekistan's climate makes spring fieldwork particularly onerous. Cotton is grown in the irrigated steppe, or semi-desert areas, where summer temperatures reach 45° Celsius (113° Fahrenheit). By late April and early May, average daytime temperatures hover around 30° Celsius (86° Fahrenheit) but can reach 35° (96° Fahrenheit). Without shade, protective gear, adequate rest periods, or water, heat stroke is common. While in Soviet times it was common for farmers to provide nutritious lunches for children

This content downloaded from
185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

in the fields, now it is increasingly rare for farm administrators to arrange any meals for the children who work for them. If they do, most often they are fed plain macaroni, or bread and tea. Usually children must bring their own food from home, which, given the low level of remuneration for this highly physically taxing work, and overwhelming rural poverty, is often a burden on families. While researching, observers eyes get full of tears seeing malnourished children faint in the fields, and how sickly many look all year before they collapse. The stark economics of hunger, inadequate food, and the lack of clean water and sanitation on work sites are most problematic in spring planting because of the extreme temperatures.

Thirsty children often resort to drinking water from irrigation or drainage canals. Even when farmers transport water directly to the fields, rather than drawing it from piped sources, they often truck in irrigation canal water instead. These are usually open canals that become vehicles for the distribution of human and animal solid waste and waste-borne pathogens. Children recruited to pick cotton near where they live are able to return home to their families in the evenings. But older children and those conscripted to work in the more remote cotton farms are forced to sleep in makeshift dormitories on farms or, ironically, in classrooms, often with poor living conditions and with insufficient and low quality food. Some children live in barracks with no electricity, windows or doors. After weeks of arduous work and poor accommodation children are left exhausted and in poor health.

Some children live in barracks with no electricity, windows, or doors. After weeks of arduous work and poor accommodation, children are left exhausted and in poor health.

5. Wages: While it is certain that the Uzbek regime exploits children in forcing them to take part in the annual cotton harvest, it is less clear how much the children are paid. Some claim to receive US $5 for five days' work. Others report receiving just 15 US cents for the same period of labor. In 2001, the Uzbek NGO, Tahlil, estimated that payment for 1 kg of cotton ranged from 1.5 US cents at the beginning of the season to 1.0 US cent at the end. In 2004, children in the Fergana region reported

This content downloaded from
185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

that an average day's harvest of 10 kg of cotton would earn them 38 US cents. For the Uzbek regime, forced child labor is undeniably cheap and immensely profitable. A child may be paid, at best, 3-4 US cents per kg for a commodity that is valued at US $1.15 on the global marketplace. Each September when the cotton harvest begins, children are being used as a cheap labor force by a government that imposes Soviet-style cotton quotas, and which is unwilling to pay a decent living wage to cotton farmers and laborers, thereby ensuring that children are used instead of adults. This practice violates the UN convention on the rights of a child.

6. Physical Conditions and Harm: In Uzbekistan children have to labor long hours with no days off over the two-month period in difficult and dangerous conditions. During weekends the work day is longer. Children inhale dust, laden with residues of chemicals, pesticides, and defoliants used in the fields before the cotton harvest. Exposure to pesticides and defoliants is demonstrably detrimental to children's health. Students are sometimes beaten by school staff for refusing to work. Human Rights Organizations confirmed eight deaths of children working in the Samarkand region over a two year period. Many more suffer chronic diseases, including intestinal infections, respiratory infections, meningitis, and hepatitis. Research divulges frequent cases of viral hepatitis contracted during spring fieldwork. Fatal outcomes are not uncommon. Amoebic dysentery and gastroenteritis are also prevalent. The cost of medical treatment can be prohibitive, or may force families into debt. Farmers are not obligated to provide such treatment for those injured or sickened while working in their fields, nor are they required to provide any compensation to families for injuries or fatalities.

The government is unwilling to pay a decent living wage to cotton farmers and laborers, thereby ensuring that children are used instead of adults. This practice violates the UN convention on the rights of a child.

7. Causes for Employing School Children: The compulsory mobilization of school children for the cotton harvest represents a distinctive break with worldwide trends. Whereas families and employers tend to be both the major initiators and beneficiaries of children's work elsewhere, Uzbekistan

This content downloaded from
185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

represents a rare instance of state-driven mass recruitment of child laborers. There are structural factors in the sense that there will always be a limited window of opportunity for bringing the harvest in, and there has been a demechanization of cotton harvesting. However, the nature of restructuring the agricultural sector is the most important factor.

In Uzbekistan, despite a number of high-profile reforms, the state continues to adopt a command economy approach, and its use of quotas pushes cotton production above those levels that market forces might dictate. The lack of market incentives means that coercion is required to reach these quotas. Farms are exposed to the vagaries of the market and the debts many farms face mean they are drawn towards making use of cheap labor. While in a few cases local authorities warn against using children, overall the need for additional labor, in order for farmers to meet their plan and avoid debt, trumped the public commitment to end the practice. Local governments were complicit in, and often actively facilitating, child labor.

In Uzbekistan, despite a number of high-profile reforms, the state continues to adopt a command economy approach, and its use of quotas pushes cotton production above those levels that market forces might dictate.

The various studies conducted by different agencies and organizations in Uzbekistan shows that the recruitment of child laborers relies on a well organized nationwide campaign that involves foresight, planning, and coordination among public agencies on many different levels of governance. Instructions are transmitted from local administrations, oblasts, and district hokimiyats (administration), to local schools and farmers who are allocated a certain contingent of children. The practice of compulsory child labor in the cotton sector of Uzbekistan is the result of public policy despite the fact that the government is a signatory to ILO Conventions that prohibit this practice.

8. Educational Loss and Effect on Schooling: In Uzbekistan most schools in rural areas are effectively shut down for about two months of the school year. There are attempts to catch up with the curriculum, but the general sense amongst parents and teachers is that the pupils' education

This content downloaded from
185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

does suffer, with a common refrain being that "of course it would be better if the children were in schools." Some parents note that when the cotton picking does not interfere with school hours, it still limits the possibility to do homework. Children mobilized for the cotton harvest experience significant educational losses. Two months of school closure during the harvest period is de facto deducted from their schooling. This represents a net loss of over 20 percent of their exposure to education. The cumulative effects of these losses over the years, between grades 5 to 9, can amount to one entire year of net school time.

Other field reports suggest that school children in rural areas may also be subject to recruitment for spring farm labor (hoeing, weeding and transplanting) occasioning further suspension of classes for weeks at a time. Thus, the total educational losses of rural school children are even higher than those identified in various studies. Many school children are acutely aware of the significance of this loss for their future prospects. They are at a clear disadvantage in comparison to their urban counterparts and are resentful of these obstacles to their social mobility. Some extracts from interviews with children, their parents, and teachers express concern and discontent with the current state of inequity.

9. State Reaction: The government of Uzbekistan has been aware for some time that the use of children in the cotton harvest could be considered as child labor. As early as 2001 there were reports of the Ministry of Health and the Ministry of Labor and Social Protection of Uzbekistan issuing a joint decree that included cotton picking as one of the worst forms of child labor. Later, independent reports by Save the Children (2002) and a UNICEF and ILO assessment conducted with government participation (2005) all highlighted the problem. Uzbekistan participated in the ILO's International Programme on the Elimination of Child Labor (IPEC), and UNICEF had also been engaging with the government on the issue (UNICEF, 2010b). Concern was also expressed by the UN Committee on the Rights of the Child. As signatory to the UN Convention of Child Rights, Uzbekistan reports periodically on progress across the whole range of child rights issues, and in response to Uzbekistan's first periodic report (2006) the Committee noted that it was "deeply concerned at the information about the involvement of the very many school-age children in the harvesting

This content downloaded from
185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

of cotton" and recommended, inter alia, that the government "establish control mechanisms to monitor the extent of all other forms of child labor, including unregulated work; address its causes with a view to enhancing prevention" (Committee on the Rights of the Child, 2006: 15). A "National Plan of Action for Securing Child Welfare in Uzbekistan," approved by the Cabinet of Ministers in January 2007, included a commitment to the "protection of children's rights in the area of labor relations" (Government of Uzbekistan, 2007a). However, the campaign in 2008 seemed to prod the Government of Uzbekistan into making a more public response. In March 2008 the parliament of Uzbekistan committed itself to a process of ratification of the two relevant ILO conventions (completed in June 2008 for Convention 182 and March 2009 for Convention 138) (ILO, 2010c).

The Ministry of Foreign Affairs issued a clarification regarding the "false and fabricated allegations" about the "mass use of forced child labor in the agriculture of Uzbekistan."

At the same time, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs issued a clarification from the Ministry of Labor regarding the "false and fabricated allegations" about the "mass use of forced child labor in the agriculture of Uzbekistan" disseminated by "biased non-governmental organizations" and some "foreign mass-media." It suggested that the real motive behind the campaign was an attempt by competitors to "lower the rating and price for Uzbek cotton ... [in order] to slow down economic growth of Uzbekistan" (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Republic of Uzbekistan, 2008).

It argued that Uzbekistan's legislation exceeded world standards in prohibiting child labor, and that completion of a privatization process in the agricultural sector meant that any child involvement in cotton picking was in the context of family farms, and as such did not count as child labor but was in line with "generally recognized family values and traditions of Uzbek society" that supported the "participation of elder children in creating the family well-being." In other words this was "child work," not "child labor." However, the policy seemed to shift somewhat by September 2008 when, in line with the commitment to implementation included in both ILO conventions, the Government of Uzbekistan introduced a National Plan of Action specifically to eliminate the worst forms of child labor. Item

This content downloaded from
185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

No. 20 of the plan committed the government to establishing a working group to "monitor locally of non-admission [sic] of the use of forced labor of pupils in schools of general education in cotton picking" and for this group to submit "analytical information to the Cabinet of Ministers on results of monitoring, with corresponding proposals" (Uzbekistan National News Agency, 2008). The responsible bodies for this working group are the Ministry of Public Education, the Ministry of Labor and Social Protection of Population, the Ministry for Foreign Economic Relations, Investments, and Trade, and also local governments (hokimyats). However, the extent to which these working groups have actually functioned, and whether monitoring has taken place, is far from clear. Uzbekistan's size and authoritarian politics make it a clear target for international campaigners. The central government's greater control over the country suggests that the mobilization of child labor has been more deliberate and systematic and its impact on schooling more profound. However, the evidence to support this has so far been patchy.

It has been argued that Uzbekistan's legislation exceeds world standards. However, the extent to which monitoring has actually taken place is far from clear.

10. Legal Dimension: Child agricultural labor violates local and international laws and norms. In terms of domestic law, child labor in Uzbekistan contravenes several items of national legislation. Article 37 of the Constitution prohibits the use of any form of forced labor. The 1991 Law on the Foundations of State Youth Policy stipulates that "it is not permitted to attract school and university students to work during the learning process, except in cases when such work corresponds to their chosen specialty and is a form of apprenticeship, or cases of voluntary collective or individual work in time free from schooling. Such labor is accepted on the condition of properly concluded contracts in accordance to labor and civic laws." The Law on Guarantees of the Right of Child to Labor adopted in 2007 states that a person younger than 18 years of age is considered to be a child. The right to employment may be exercised from 16 years onwards and, in some cases (with the consent of parents and during periods free from study), from 14 years on. At the same time the state guarantees the labor rights for persons younger

This content downloaded from
185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

than 18 years by providing the necessary conditions for combining work with compulsory education (Article 20). Article 20 makes clear stipulations concerning the conditions under which children may be permitted to work including: (1) Every child has the right to work, free choice of the type of activity and profession, fair labor conditions appropriate to his/her age, state of health and professional training in accordance with the procedure prescribed by the law. (2) Application for a job is permitted from the age of 16. (3) Persons who reach the age of 15 can be accepted for a job by written consent of either parents or guardians. (4) To prepare the children for work, it is permitted to recruit the pupils of secondary schools, academic lyceums, and professional colleges to carry out an easy job that does not harm their health and growth or infringe upon the educational process, free from school hours—upon reaching the age of 14 by written consent of either of parents or guardians. Article 7 of the Labor Code of the Republic of Uzbekistan on "Prohibition of forced labor" clearly states that forced labor, namely a compulsion to work under the threat of any punishment (including as a means to ensure labor discipline) is prohibited except when it is executed on the basis of legal acts on military or alternative services, in a state of emergency, as a result of a court verdict coming into force or other cases envisaged by the legislation. Article 241 of the Labor Code, also prohibits the use of children for any work that may damage their health, security and morality. The Government of Uzbekistan points out that these provisions are in full compliance with the international legal provisions on protection of children's rights and, in particular, the 1989 Convention on the Rights of the Child. However, there is widespread international concern in relation to the actual implementation of these laws.

11. Use of force and the Societal Attitude towards Children's Work: The study presents a picture of a systematic mobilization of children by the central state that utilizes the school system and leaves almost no room for choices at the level of children and parents and remarkably little agency on the part of the school authorities and even farmers. The farmers have their own incentives to involve children. The schools are clearly central to the mobilization of children, with teachers largely supervising the work. Evidence of pressure applied to children to become involved is mixed, with some reports of strong pressure and in other cases less so. There is,

This content downloaded from
185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

undoubtedly, a Soviet legacy of mobilization for cotton harvests which used to be accompanied with propaganda and "socialist competition" among harvest brigades in order to push up production norms. However, cotton cultivators were also the beneficiaries of health, education, and welfare entitlements that increased their social wage. Exhortations to participate in the production of national wealth under current conditions breed cynicism and discontent, which is further exacerbated by the exploitation of children.

The use of children ensures maximum profits to the ruling elite, which benefits from the supply of cotton to western consumers. The use of child labor violates international laws and conventions to which the government of Uzbekistan is a signatory. Children's normal education is interrupted to serve the interest of the small elite who benefit grossly from the high profits from trading cotton on the world market. As a result of forced child labor, children cannot learn in schools and colleges during the academic period, and lag behind in the school curriculum, while a large number of children fall sick from hard work and exhaustion.

The use of children ensures maximum profits to the ruling elite, which benefits from the supply of cotton to western consumers.

There is a pressing need for adequate data and methodologically sound instruments to monitor patterns of child labor in the cotton sector of Uzbekistan. Specialist UN agencies such as UNICEF and ILO must, in dialogue with the government of Uzbekistan, break with the precedent set by flawed MIC surveys and redouble their efforts to achieve a reliable database as a guide to future policy.

12. Conclusions, Policy Implications, and Suggestions: The research confirms that child labor, as defined by the ILO, is widely used in the cotton harvests of both Uzbekistan and Tajikistan. The extent of the problem is significantly greater in Uzbekistan, where child labor is on a larger scale and more intense, and where the practice of coercion is more ubiquitous. Little has changed in Uzbekistan since the ratification of the ILO conventions. In using the comparative approach and seeking to understand "what has changed" since independence from the Soviet Union, we conclude that the dynamics of how children are mobilized vary between the two countries.

This content downloaded from
185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

In Tajikistan, farmers appear to play a more proactive role in recruiting children for the cotton harvest, negotiating with schools and with various local authorities acting as brokers to varying degrees in different districts. Schools seemed to be more autonomous in their decision to involve their children and often had a pecuniary incentive to do so—often keeping back payments due to the children in order to cover the additional costs of running the school. In Uzbekistan, farmers and schools exercise much less agency. The surveys reveal a consistent picture of the district hokimyat (town hall) orchestrating the mobilization for the cotton harvest. This appears part of a wider hierarchy of mobilization in which a national target for the harvest is broken down into quotas which are then enforced at each level of the state administration right down to the individual quotas for a child in the field. At each level of the hierarchy there are both explicit and implicit threats in the event of non-compliance, reflecting a greater penetrative capacity of state structures than in Tajikistan.

In Tajikistan, the central government seems less able to control the dynamic of child labor at the local level, hence the greater variance in its use. The survey confirms that both the 2006 presidential decree and a Ministry of Education decree prohibiting child labor in cotton fields have had limited impact, with low levels of awareness of their existence amongst teachers and with local leaders seemingly having greater autonomy to contradict these decrees. The continued use of child labor in both countries is not surprising given that the root causes have not significantly changed over the last few years. As such, making progress on eliminating the use of forced child labor in the cotton harvest is dependent on broader changes in agricultural production in both countries.

In the case of Uzbekistan, where the use of child labor remains an unspoken national policy, steps need to be taken from the top accompanied by a more genuine commitment to transparently monitor compliance at the local level, in line with commitments made in the ILO conventions. However, no one pretends that this will be a simple process, and this endeavor must form part of a wider reform of the agricultural sector that is attuned to the problem of landlessness and founded on a commitment to increase the welfare of the whole rural population. The dynamics in Tajikistan are more complex, as children's participation is determined by a number of local factors including the scale of the harvest and availability of

This content downloaded from
185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

adult labor, the financial state of the farms and the politics of farm financing, along with the policies of local government bodies and schools. How these different factors combine to produce the local variations observed in the survey is an area for future research, but what it does present is a greater opportunity for interventions at the sub-national level that would support the local administration in effectively implementing both the agricultural restructuring and bans on child labor that are signaled by central government.

Although the Government of Uzbekistan has adopted the necessary legal framework for the eradication of forced child labor, both as signatory to international treaties and through domestic legislation, it appears to be in breach of both. The involvement of state parties in the mobilization of child labor for cotton harvests cannot be glossed over. The extended suspension of schooling and the organized large scale deployment of children on cotton fields can hardly take place without the support of the central government and the active involvement of local administrations. Without verifiable benchmarks and systematic monitoring, the NAP may remain a dead issue given the lack of concrete steps to reform the agrarian sector and to lift the current constraints on the operations of the cotton sector.

Although Uzbekistan has adopted the necessary legal framework for the eradication of forced child labor, both as signatory to international treaties and through domestic legislation, it appears to be in breach of both.

The root causes of reliance on coerced labor should be recognized and remedied through a package of reforms that address the vicious cycle of a partially modified command economy, the plight of labor, declining productivity, and low incomes in the cotton farming sector. These are factors that fuel rural poverty and erode trust in governance and administration. In order to assess the real magnitude of the employment of minors, an in-depth study is necessary, particularly in regions with high unemployment rates. The major factors contributing to the supply and demand of unemployment of minors need to be better researched as well.

Thorough reform of the agricultural economy is necessary in order to replace the cheap and easily coerced farm labor that Uzbekistan's

This content downloaded from
185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

schoolchildren now provide. Artificial suppression of purchase prices for agricultural commodities such as cotton will have to be removed so that farmers are able to cover the real market cost of the labor required to grow and harvest such crops. Opening the market in agriculture and abolishing obligatory state quotas for cotton and wheat may be required.

Uzbekistan, with its massive unemployment, was and is entirely able to eliminate forced child labor. The country already has several laws on the books that would, if respected, ban children's forced labor on the cotton harvest. The practice clearly violates Uzbekistan's own longstanding statutes on the rights of children and the labor code including its provisions on the minimum age and conditions of children's work. Despite these laws, over the past decade, the government has only intensified its reliance on forced child labor to bring in the cotton harvest, due to a number of economic and political factors. Among these are the persistence of elements of a command economy in the sector, and constraints on a free labor market.

Artificial suppression of purchase prices for agricultural commodities such as cotton will have to be removed so that farmers are able to cover the real market cost of the labor required to grow and harvest such crops.

Meaningful steps toward ending the problem are well within the reach of the Government of Uzbekistan; the principal obstacle to taking such steps is political will. Under its commitments to the recently signed ILO Convention No. 182, the Uzbek government is obligated to provide the ILO a list of sectors where worst forms of child labor are found. Public acknowledgement of the problem through public identification of cotton as a target sector is one important precursor to further action.

The government of Uzbekistan needs to put in place a comprehensive national action plan to end forced labor in the cotton industry and commit all resources necessary to the implementation of this action plan. Independent journalists and human rights defenders should be given unrestricted access to document the situation during the cotton harvest and address and evaluate the situation of forced child labor through annual reports on human rights, human trafficking, and labor issues. There should

This content downloaded from
185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

be encouragement to the World Bank and the Asian Development bank to resume their efforts to promote reform in Uzbekistan's agricultural and cotton sectors as forced child labor is symptomatic of incomplete reform of these sectors of the economy and the lack of farmers' rights to manage their own assets and products. Multilateral organizations, including the International Labor Organization, should be encouraged to make public statements through annual and thematic reports about violations of labor and human rights in Uzbekistan's cotton industry.

Agriculture has gone through considerable changes in Uzbekistan and, with the completion of the conversion of the shirkhat into private farms, there is a need to monitor the impact on child labor. Though the exercise of structured child labor via schools in conjecture might begin to grow fainter, it may well nudge the problem to the family level, where children will continue to be deployed on family farms—the least synchronized and potentially most exploitative appearance of child labor. The structure of the agricultural sector and the limited window of opportunity for bringing in the harvest leads to the conclusion that the mobilization of the whole community to bring in the harvest is likely to continue. During the 1990s labor productivity was low and employment creation in rural areas was hampered by the effectively high taxation of the agricultural sector through the quota system, whereby the prices for cotton and grain were fixed below world price levels. This discouraged investment into technology and more capital-intensive agriculture, and increased reliance on the type of low-skill jobs and experience that children have.

The effectively high taxation of the agricultural sector through the quota system and fixing prices for cotton and grain below world price levels discourages capital investment into technology.

There is a pressing need for adequate data and methodologically sound instruments to monitor patterns of child labor in the cotton sector of Uzbekistan. Specialist UN agencies such as UNICEF and ILO must, in dialogue with the government of Uzbekistan, break with the precedent set by flawed surveys by various agencies and redouble their efforts to achieve a reliable data base as a guide to future policy.

This content downloaded from
185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

There is no lack of regulation concerning child labor, and as the Uzbekistan government's 2005 report to the CRC Committee points out, the "labor legislation norms are more favorable than the minimum norms envisaged by the international legal acts on labor and by the ILO Conventions." The problem with regulation is the lack of mechanisms for enforcement; labor inspectors need to be better focused on the violations taking place. The main issue for regulation, however, is to better focus on the issue of use of child labor in bringing in the cotton harvest. Currently there is no regulation addressing this in education or labor laws. This leaves local authorities to be the arbiter of the duration of children's cotton harvesting works, conditions, and payment. The importance to the economy of this practice must be more openly debated and a reasoned discussion is called for, seeing how children might become involved in ways that are not detrimental to their health and education. The incentive structure built into the quota system must be examined so that local authorities are penalized rather than being rewarded for exploitative forms of child labor.

Those who benefit from Uzbek forced child labor, the Uzbek comprador elite and the First World, are a global minority. In contrast, the Uzbek masses are part of a larger majority, the vast Third World masses. According to the Environmental Justice Foundation, 250 million children around the world are compelled to work, presumably in commodity exchange industries. Adding to this are the world's exploited adults, those languishing in vast urban slums and subsistence communities under constant threat of being kicked off the land. Together, the vast Third World masses pose a serious threat to the system: they carry great potential and a historical responsibility.

The need for an open debate is essential for reasonable regulation to be developed, and the way to start is greater transparency and data around the issue. The question put by the CRC Committee concerning "the number of children involved in labor who are under 16" unfortunately went unanswered in the government's reply. The government's plan to carry out research into this issue during the harvest season is to be commended and is a positive step in the right direction.

Transforming the cotton industry in Uzbekistan will not be simple. Structural reforms could have stimulated the growth of cotton productivity, which would be beneficial for the cotton industry, farmers, and ordinary

This content downloaded from
185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

people alike. Cotton monoculture is more disastrous for the future of Uzbekistan than the tons of heroine which are regularly transported throughout the Central-Asian region. Even though the international community has invested millions of dollars in anti-narcotics programs, it has done far too little to fight against the negative effects of the Uzbek cotton industry. Achieving real changes in the cotton sector will take time, but true reform of this sector could provide more stability in this strategic country than the international community can imagine.

References

Sharma, R. R. (1979) *A Marxist Model of Social Change: Soviet Central Asia: 1917-1940.* Delhi.

Patnaik, Ajay (2003) *Nations Minorities and States in Central Asia.* Kolkata.

Kaushik, Devendra (1970) *Central Asia in Modern Times.* Moscow.

Kandiyoti, D. (2008) *Invisible to the World: The Dynamics of Forced Child Labor in the Cotton Sector of Uzbekistan.* London: School of Oriental and African Studies.

International Labor Rights Forum (ILRF) (2008) We Live Subject to Their Orders: A Three Province Survey of Forced Child Labor in Uzbekistan's 2008 Cotton Harvest. Tashkent and New York.

State Statistical Agency (2003) Uzbekistan in Numbers 2002: Statistical Overview. Tashkent. World Bank. 2002. Labor Market and Unemployment in Uzbekistan. Available at http://siteresources.worldbank.org.

World Organization Against Torture (OMCT) (2006) *Rights of the Child in Uzbekistan.* Geneva: UN Committee on the Rights of the Child.

Bhat Bilal Ahmad (2011) "Socioeconomic Dimensions of Child Labor in Central Asia: A Case Study of the Cotton Industry in Uzbekistan" *Problems of Economic Transition,* vol. 54, no. 1, May 2011, pp. 84–99.

This content downloaded from
185.139.137.47 on Tue, 24 Feb 2026 19:03:47 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms